

FIGHTING ILLINI SQUEEZE THE DAY

Illinois holds off South Carolina in Citrus Bowl thriller, claims double-digit wins for first time since 2001 **Chicago Sports**

WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

WEDNESDAY, JANUARY 1, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Laws include focus on wages, AI

As state lawmakers prepare to return, hundreds of changes take effect. Here are some of the biggest

By **Jeremy Gorner and Olivia Olander**
Chicago Tribune

Some 300 new state laws take effect Wednesday covering everything from road safety to artificial intelligence, most of them passed

during a two-year legislative term that enters its final days when lawmakers return to Springfield this week.

The Democratic-led General Assembly is scheduled to meet for four days before a new legislature is inaugurated on Jan. 8.

The attention of the new General Assembly — still controlled by Democratic supermajorities in both chambers — may turn toward efforts to preemptively counter federal action that might be taken by Republican President-elect Donald Trump's administration in such areas as immigration, abortion rights or environmental policy, leaders have said.

Lawmakers could also take up

measures that make it easier for the state's child welfare system to have a child's family member as a legal guardian, eliminate barriers for individuals wanting to change their names and implement regulations on the hemp industry, among other things.

But perhaps the biggest issue awaiting the new General Assembly is how to confront a projected shortfall of nearly \$3.2 billion for

the next state budget. Complicating the fiscal picture will be deliberations over whether to pass legislation adjusting the state's pension system; a proposal to consolidate the Chicago area's transit agencies; and determining whether Chicago's public schools should get more robust funding than in past years.

Turn to New Laws, Page 2



The Blackhawks arrive for the NHL Winter Classic against the St. Louis Blues at Wrigley Field on Tuesday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

CAN'T RAIN ON THIS PARADE

By **Peter Breen**
Chicago Tribune

In the eyes of Chicagoan Conrad Brewer, 8, there was too much recognition of the St. Louis Blues in the form of statues, flags and other signage at the fan festival before Tuesday's hockey game at Wrigley Field.

"Since it's in the Chicago hometown, I think we should have more Chicago Blackhawks things than Blues," Brewer said late Tuesday morning as a light rain fell on a parking lot a block north of the field, where festivities would go on until 3:30 p.m., a half hour before the NHL Winter Classic puck drop.

Brewer predicted that the last-place Hawks would prevail against their division rival, the .500 Blues, by a score of 2-1. The Hawks would strike first. Then the Blues

Struggling Blackhawks and lousy weather fail to dampen spirits ahead of Winter Classic at Wrigley



Wrigley makes Winter Classic a must-see event, despite two must-miss teams in the Blackhawks and Blues, writes Paul Sullivan. **Chicago Sports**

would tie it up. Ultimately, the hometown squad would carry the day.

On the ice, the visitors from St. Louis won the game, 6-2.

The Hawks entered on a four-game slide and hadn't won an outdoor game since 2014.

A steady stream of fans in red and black equipped with umbrellas and ponchos — sprinkled with fans in royal blue and gold, also equipped with rain gear — were advised by greeters near the festival entrance on West Grace Street that to the left there was a free hot chocolate table for alleviating woes that possibly stemmed from the dreary weather and the recent poor fortune of Chicago sports teams.

The hot chocolate came with marshmallows infused with Pepsi.

Turn to Blackhawks, Page 5

Mideast turmoil lingers in new year

Cautious optimism, despair about future range across region

By **Ghaith Alsayed, Wafaa Shurafa and Lujain Jo**
Associated Press

DAMASCUS — In Damascus, the streets were buzzing with excitement Tuesday as Syrians welcomed in a new year that seemed to many to bring a promise of a brighter future after the unexpected fall of Bashar Assad's government weeks earlier.

While Syrians in the capital looked forward to a new beginning after the ousting of Assad, the mood was more somber along Beirut's Mediterranean promenade, where residents shared cautious hopes for the new year, reflecting on a country still reeling from war and ongoing crises.

War-weary Palestinians in Gaza who lost their homes and loved ones in 2024 saw little hope that 2025 would bring an end to their suffering.

The past year was a dramatic one in the Middle East, bringing calamity to some and hope to others. Across the region, it felt foolish to many to attempt to predict what the next year might bring.

In Damascus, Abir Homsy said she is optimistic about a future for her country that would include peace, security and freedom of expression and would bring Syrian communities previously divided by battle lines back together.

"We will return to how we once were, when people loved each other, celebrated together whether it is Ramadan or Christmas or any other holiday — no restricted areas for anyone," she said.

But for many, the new year

Turn to Mideast, Page 9

Flu, RSV on the rise in Chicagoland

Easily transmittable norovirus also threatening amid an otherwise 'kind of typical' virus season

By **Lisa Schencker**
Chicago Tribune

Leslee Cohen-Lavin and her family were feeling pretty good just before the holidays.

"Then all of a sudden, we each went down right when break started," said Cohen-Lavin, of Highland Park. Her 5-year-old daughter got a fever and aches and lost her appetite. Soon, Cohen-Lavin developed a days-long fever.

Finally, her husband got what felt like a head cold. They canceled most of their plans for winter break.

"It's been a tough break, but it could be a lot worse," said Cohen-Lavin, whose family is now on the upswing.

It's a common sentiment right now throughout Chicagoland, because it's not just the holiday season, it's also a far less celebrated time of year — respiratory virus and stomach bug season.

As Chicago residents have been partaking in festivities over the past several weeks, various illnesses have taken hold. Flu activity "continues to rapidly increase," RSV activity is "very high," and COVID-19 activity is low but increasing, according to a Dec. 27 Chicago Department of Public Health surveillance summary. Statewide, the percentages of positive tests for the flu and RSV also have been increasing, as have the percentages of emergency department visits for those

Turn to Viruses, Page 4



Medical assistant Jada Lee gives COVID and flu shots to a patient at the Rush West Loop Clinic on Tuesday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 31 Low 21

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
177th year No. 1 © Chicago Tribune

